

You don't have to reveal your budget to the dollar, but give an indication of the ballpark sum, or a range, to get the most out of your enquiries with agents. McCarthy says, 'You don't have to provide us with the absolute maximum, but it helps us if we have a gauge, and the more upfront you are, the more we can be upfront in turn. It's a two-way street.'

Wish list

Make an inventory of what you really must have in a property, McCarthy advises, and share it with the agent to help them to narrow down a home that fits your needs. It might not be the listing you have enquired about but something else on their books, current or future. 'List five or ten things that are non-negotiable – someone with pets might want a slightly bigger backyard, or a train station might be really important,' she says. 'Have a list of another five or ten things that would be nice to have, but if you can't, it won't be the end of the world, and then a handful of things that you definitely don't want in a home.'

Here's my own home checklist, as an example:

Must-haves

- Walkable access to a train station
- Five-minute drive to a grocery store
- A second bedroom
- At least one outdoor area, of any size
- Island bench in the kitchen (anything else is too small and impractical for my dedication to cooking)
- A view of some sort – I can manage happily in a small space as long as I have an aspect to enjoy, which adds to the sense of space – such as the streetscape, trees, city lights or rooftops.

Desired but can live without

- An older apartment is a financially savvy move for me, and therefore my first choice
- An ensuite for the main bedroom
- A bathroom with a bath, for future children (or my visiting family)
- Off-street parking
- North-facing orientation